



Exploring the value of *pro bono* evaluation work as a method to build evaluator competencies and strengthen organizational capacity

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ABSTRACT

The *Cultivating Evaluation Education and Development* (CEED) program engages early career evaluators in an experiential learning experience by supporting them as they lead a *pro bono* evaluation for a local nonprofit community organization. We explored the value of this professional development to the early career evaluators, to the sponsor organization, and to the nonprofit organizations receiving CEED services by examining findings from six CEED projects. We found that early career evaluators self-reported gains in confidence and competence especially in four American Evaluation Association Evaluator Competencies (2018) domains - *professional practice, methodology, planning and management, and interpersonal skills*. The initiative allowed the sponsor organization to expand connections with community organizations, implement work consistent with the mission, and provide new mentoring opportunities. Representatives from the recipient nonprofit organizations reported they gained a deeper understanding of evaluation, improved their dissemination efforts, and built organizational evaluation capacity.

1. Introduction

To conduct ethical, high-quality program evaluations, practitioners must apply a large and varied set of knowledge, skills, and dispositions. This broad capability is evident in the [American Evaluation Association Evaluator \(AEA\) Competencies \(2018, 2022\)](#), which include five domains and 49 competencies. While all the skills do not automatically apply to every evaluator ([King & Stevahn, 2020](#)), AEA intends that the “competencies serve as a roadmap for guiding evaluator education and training” (p 1). In this article, we explore one professional development program that is situated within the AEA Evaluator Competencies. The program, entitled *Cultivating Evaluation Education and Development* (CEED), is an initiative of The Evaluation Center at the University of Colorado Denver (CU Denver) that is intended to build the capacity of early career evaluators. The CEED program engages early career evaluators in an experiential learning experience by supporting them as they lead a *pro bono* evaluation for a local nonprofit community organization.

1.1. Research call

This study responds to the call from [Davies and MacKay \(2014\)](#) to conduct research to learn how small programs provide early career

evaluators with experience, especially approaches that emphasize the development of professional and evaluator dispositions. We are also responding to the call to advance evaluator education by exploring and documenting quality evaluator training in both formal and informal settings ([Gullickson et al., 2019](#)). We hope to contribute to the field by documenting evaluator in-service professional development programs, an area identified as a research gap by [King and Ayoo \(2020\)](#) and exploring the usefulness of the competencies as a structure for experiential introductions to the field of evaluation as recommended by [Hall \(2020\)](#).

2. Literature review

2.1. Need for evaluator capacity building

Evaluators enter the profession from a variety of disciplines (e.g., psychology, sociology, education, anthropology). This interdisciplinary diversity is a strength that supports evaluation teams comprised of individuals who have unique perspectives and content expertise. However, the variations in undergraduate and graduate training also result in early career evaluators who have a range of development of evaluator competencies. [Christie, Quinones, and Fierro \(2014\)](#) found 65% of a

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sample of 292 practicing evaluators reported taking general research design and methods course, but fewer than 25% had evaluation theory or practice coursework. Galport and Azzam (2016) found that in a sample of approximately 400 AEA members, fewer than 10% held a degree with a specific focus in evaluation.

Even for those completing formal evaluation courses, there is often minimal exposure to many of the AEA Evaluator Competencies. Researchers found that university-based evaluation courses focus mainly on research design and methodology with few courses spending time on project implementation or client engagement (Davies & MacKay, 2014; Gullickson et al., 2019).

Practical experience in evaluation was viewed as the missing component from many training programs; fewer than 30% of programs offer practicums or internship opportunities (Engle et al., 2006). Evaluators reported they often engage in more informal professional development (e.g., workshops, conferences, webinars) to continue to build their skills (Christie, 2014), but these opportunities seldom provide actual experience conducting a complete evaluation. Providing early career evaluators with evaluation experience is viewed as essential to build their capacity as effective practitioners (Dewey et al., 2008; Worthen, 1999; Yarbrough, 2011; Davies & MacKay, 2014).

2.2. Foundations of the CEED approach

In addition to the goal of enhancing the competency of early career evaluators, the CEED program is intended to build evaluation capacity in the local nonprofit community organizations selected to receive services *pro bono* (literally “for the public good”). These small organizations are purposefully selected because they are unlikely to have the resources to engage professional evaluators or to participate in formal evaluation training. This feature of the CEED program aligns with the AEA End Goals (AEA Policies) that encourage practitioners to engage in efforts to build evaluation skills and knowledge in local groups and to increase the understanding of the value of evaluation as a tool to address challenging issues and solutions. Wade and Kallemeyn (2020) found evidence of the sustained impact on organizations participating in evaluation capacity building interventions.

Providing *pro bono* services is a well-established practice in the legal, health care, and finance professions. We found two other evaluation organizations that are also engaged in providing *pro bono* services (although there may be others). The Atlanta-Area Evaluation Association Pro-Bono-Work, (2022) and the Washington Evaluators (Evaluation without Borders, 2022), both professional organizations affiliated with AEA, have programs to match members with local organizations in their communities. These initiatives appear to differ from the CEED program because, in the Atlanta and Washington programs, the evaluator is an unpaid volunteer drawn from multiple evaluation organizations, whereas CEED lead evaluators and mentors are employees of the The Evaluation Center at CU Denver, and the *pro bono* work is part of their assigned duties.

2.3. Learning frameworks

The CEED approach is grounded in competency-based learning, a framework that aligns educational experiences with an agreed-upon set of outcomes (Frank et al., 2010). This model is frequently applied in educational programs where it is important to connect preservice training with professional roles. In this case, we draw upon the 2018 AEA Evaluator Competencies as descriptors of the intended outcomes. CEED also employs the strategy of experiential learning in the workplace (Kolb, 1984; Yardley et al., 2012) as the CEED lead evaluator is actively engaged in implementing an actual evaluation including initial client contact, development of a focused plan, data collection and analysis, and presentation of results or agreed-upon deliverables. Both competency-based and experiential learning frameworks are learner-centered. In the CEED program, early career evaluators serving

as CEED lead evaluators regularly self-assess their progress, identify their goals for continued development, and reflect on their competency development.

The self-reflection process is also an opportunity for evaluators to examine their commitment to social justice and to recognize how power, privilege, and culture affect an evaluation (van Draanen, 2017; Froncek et al., 2018; Symonette et al., 2020). Self-reflection also supports the development of cultural competencies that are represented across the domains of the AEA Evaluator Competencies (King & Stevahn, 2020). The local community organizations supported by the CEED projects are often engaged in work that supports diversity, equity, and inclusion, which presents unique opportunities for both the early career evaluator and the mentor to engage in culturally responsive reflection and growth.

3. Context

The Evaluation Center is a self-supporting unit within CU Denver. Since 2004, The Evaluation Center has provided fee-for-service evaluation for clients in schools, institutions of higher education, governmental agencies, and nonprofit organizations. In 2017, we decided to launch CEED as an internal initiative for evaluator professional development. We designed the program to provide early career evaluators on our team with experience by conducting *pro bono* evaluations for selected recipient nonprofit organizations with the support and guidance of a more experienced mentor. The impetus for the program was in response to two identified organizational needs – to provide our early career team members with hands on experiences to support their professional development as evaluators and to gain a deeper understanding of the workings and evaluation requirements of local nonprofit community groups.

3.1. Structure

The CEED workgroup within The Evaluation Center at CU Denver facilitates the selection and implementation of *pro bono* projects annually. A primary consideration is the availability of at least one team member who is interested in the experience of leading a CEED project and one or more team members who are willing to serve as a mentor for the project leader. In the 5 years of the program’s existence, these roles have been easily filled by team members who assume these responsibilities in addition to their regular assigned duties. Each CEED project is bounded in time and effort with the cost of the CEED lead evaluator and mentor evaluators’ time absorbed by The Evaluation Center at CU Denver.

3.2. Selection process

Each year the CEED workgroup publicizes the opportunity for *pro bono* evaluation services to potential recipients identified through our community networks and their online profiles. We must limit our *pro bono* work to one project annually because The Evaluation Center at CU Denver is completely funded by providing fee-for-service evaluation services to paying clients. Non-billable activities such as the CEED program must be balanced such that they do not take away capacity to complete paid evaluation work. We continue to look for opportunities to expand the CEED program, while maintaining this balance.

The criteria for the applicant pool has evolved over time. Initially, the CEED workgroup publicized the opportunity across a wide range of community organizations in Denver metropolitan area. In subsequent years, we narrowed the focus to recruit organizations whose mission was of high interest to both the early career evaluator who would lead the project and our organization. In 2020, we actively recruited nonprofit organizations that work with underserved populations in alignment with our desire to develop our capacity to engage in equitable evaluation practices to support social justice (Equitable Evaluation Framework, n.d.; Donaldson & Piccioto, 2016; Symonette et al., 2020). As an

organization, we wanted to gain experience evaluating programs that have an equity-focused mission and to enhance our ability to use equitable evaluation practices with grass-roots community groups.

In 2022, we expanded our geographic area to the state of Colorado to allow options for virtual interactions and focused our recruiting on organizations working in the field of youth mental health. We anticipate the focus of the CEED program will continue to evolve in response to team interests and needs in the future.

Once the recruitment focus is defined, we identify nonprofit organizations whose mission, vision, and values aligns with our goals and who are not actively engaged with other evaluation services. We review available financial information to develop a list of potential organizations who likely would not have sufficient resources to employ an external evaluator. Potential recipients are then sent introductory emails including a link to the The Evaluation Center website (<https://www.the-evaluation-center.org>).

The CEED website includes information on the value of evaluation for nonprofit organizations, especially for those focusing on equity work. During the search time window, interested groups (those recruited and others viewing the website) can apply online to be considered to receive CEED services. The application asks for information about the structure of the organization and for a description of their evaluation needs. We ask about time and staff available for capacity development to explore their ability to sustain the evaluation work beyond the *pro bono* services. For each selection round, we have received multiple applications from nonprofit organizations that qualify, making selection a challenging task. The CEED workgroup and the early career evaluator who will lead the project review all applications and select one or more for follow-up interviews with key applicant personnel; the recipient is selected based on the consensus of the workgroup members and project leader.

3.3. Services

The recipient nonprofit organization receives up to 75 hours of free evaluation services over 6–12 months. The goal is to build the capacity of the recipient organization to continue to conduct evaluations on their own after their CEED connection concludes. Therefore, we meet with the recipient nonprofit organization's leaders to determine the areas for collaboration that will be most beneficial and have a long-lasting impact on their work. Potential areas include evaluation training, logic model development, instrument development, data collection, and data analysis. However, by necessity, the *pro bono* collaboration must be bounded so that it can be realistically accomplished within the time allotted for the scope of work.

During implementation, the early career evaluator leads the CEED project to gain experience at all stages of an evaluation including focusing the work, preparing the necessary memorandum of understanding, and engaging in the mutually agreed upon scope of work. Throughout the project, a more senior evaluator serves as their mentor providing feedback and training, as needed, on evaluation best practices, client engagement, and project management. We consider the time the senior evaluator spends mentoring as part of their role to provide professional development to new evaluators and, therefore, is not included in the 75-hour scope of work for the recipient nonprofit organization.

The mentor and CEED project leader meet regularly to discuss the project, troubleshoot any challenges, and reflect on evaluation skills and practices. In monthly workgroup meetings, the CEED project leader reports on the status of the evaluation and shares lessons learned, especially as related to the AEA Evaluator Competencies. All team members at The Evaluation Center at CU Denver are familiar with the AEA Evaluator Competencies as new staff self-assess their skills using an online format at the time of hiring and annually during performance reviews. (Our self-assessment instrument is provided in the [supplemental appendices](#)).

3.4. CEED community organizations

Six nonprofit organizations have received CEED services since 2017 (Table 1). The projects ranged in duration from 5 to 11 months. Each project had two or three areas of capacity building that were identified as areas of need by the partner group. The areas of evaluation capacity building included evaluation design, survey development, and training for staff in either data collection methods, data analysis, or data visualization.

4. Methods

After implementing six CEED projects, we engaged in a self-study of the initiative to determine if the program was achieving its intended outcomes and to explore the value of the program for both The Evaluation Center at CU Denver and the recipient nonprofit organizations. Our institutional review board advised us that they considered the self-study to be exempt from human subjects' research oversight.

4.1. Study questions

The following questions guided the self-study of the CEED program:

- 1) To what extent do early career evaluators gain confidence and competencies in evaluation by serving as a CEED project leader?

Table 1

Recipient Nonprofit Organizations Participating in Pro Bono Evaluation Program.

Identifier	Organization Activities	Evaluation Capacity Building Areas	Project Start	Project Duration
Org #1	Creates pathways and opportunities for youth and young adults to enter and maintain natural resource careers	Evaluation design Survey development	July 2017	5 mo.
Org #2	Collects data on the wild Pika in the Rocky Mountains as part of a community science research project	Evaluation design Survey development	April 2018	10 mo.
Org #3	Facilitates an international program and competition where middle and high school students innovate creative solutions to global issues	Evaluation design Survey development Data analysis	April 2018	9 mo.
Org #4	Offers supportive and comprehensive adoption services at every stage of the adoption process for both birth families and adoptive and foster care families	Survey methods & development Data visualization	Jan 2020	10 mo.
Org #5	Develops the leadership skills and capacity in Latinx youth around the topics of policy, organizing, and communications	Evaluation design Qualitative data collection & analysis Dissemination	Feb 2020	11 mo.
Org #6	Aims to mentor and empower young women through providing mental health services, personal development, transitional housing, entrepreneurship training, and educational opportunities	Evaluation design Survey development	May 2022	Ongoing

- 2) What is the value of the CEED program to The Evaluation Center at CU Denver?
- 3) What is the value of the CEED program to community nonprofit organizations receiving *pro bono* evaluation services?

4.2. Data collection procedures

We collected data from several sources for the self-study. To explore impact on evaluator competency for those serving as CEED project leaders, we reviewed the end-of-project summaries that are prepared by CEED project leaders and their mentors. We offer a template to structure these summaries and collect reflections on the lessons and skills learned. (The project summary template is provided in the [supplemental appendices](#)).

To further our understanding of the impact of the professional development on individuals and to explore the benefits to our organization, we conducted a focus group in June 2022 with six evaluators who led CEED projects and/or served as mentors; the focus group was facilitated by a member of our team who had not previously been involved in the CEED program (lead author). Focus group questions are provided in the [supplementary appendix](#).

To explore the impact on recipient nonprofit organizations, a team member who had not participated in the CEED project conducted a follow-up interview with a representative of the organization that had received CEED services. To assess the initial impact, an initial debrief interview was conducted approximately 3 months after completion of the project. To explore longer-term impact, we conducted a second follow-up interview with CEED organization representatives approximately 1 to 2 years later. In total, we conducted nine interviews with twelve individuals from recipient nonprofit organization (Table 2). Interview questions are provided in the [supplemental appendices](#).

4.3. Data analysis

Data analysis was conducted independently by a team member who served on the CEED work group but had not served as a CEED project lead or mentor (second author). Results were reviewed and confirmed by a second team member (lead author). We completed qualitative coding of the written summaries/reflections and the interview and focus group transcripts. The AEA Evaluator Competencies were used as themes for coding; we also conducted open coding to capture emerging themes. We identified examples within these general categories and identified illustrative quotes for each area.

5. Results

5.1. Early career evaluator competencies development

The early career evaluators who led a CEED project consistently self-reported individual professional growth and skill development in the AEA Evaluator Competencies across all five domains. Nine specific competencies in four domains were most frequently cited as areas of growth (Table 3). Below the growth in each of these four domains is further described and examples given.

Table 2
Interviews with Recipient Nonprofit Organizations Participating in CEED.

Identifier	Debrief Interview	Debrief Participants (n)	Roles of Participants	Follow-up Participants (n)	Roles of Participants
Org #1	Dec 2017	2	Program Coordinator Program Director	0	–
Org #2	Jan 2019	2	Program Directors	1	Leadership Team
Org #3	Jan 2019	1	Program Director	1	Program Director
Org #4	Jan 2021	2	Program Director Grants & Evaluation	1	Grants & Evaluation
Org #5	March 2021	1	Chief Operating Officer	1	Executive Director

Table 3
Areas of Capacity Building for Early Career Evaluators.

AEA Domain	AEA Competencies
1.0 Professional Practice	1.8 Identifies how evaluation practice can promote social justice and the public good.
2.0 Methodology	2.1 Identifies evaluation purposes and needs 2.8 Involves stakeholders in designing, implementing, interpreting, and reporting evaluations as appropriate.
4.0 Planning and Management	4.1 Negotiates and manages a feasible evaluation plan, budget, resources, and timeline. 4.6 Documents evaluation processes and products 4.9 Works with stakeholders to build evaluation capacity when appropriate.
5.0 Interpersonal	5.1 Fosters positive relationships for professional practice and evaluation use 5.3 Facilitates shared decision making for evaluation 5.4 Builds trust throughout the evaluation

5.1.1. Professional practice domain

Early career evaluators described how leading a CEED project furthered their understanding of how evaluation work can promote social justice and serve the public good. They reported that they expanded their practice by interacting with recipient nonprofit organizations whose mission and vision aligned with increasing equity. For example, in the work with Org #5, the CEED evaluator described how they developed an evaluation plan specifically to assess the organization's ability to develop leadership skills in Latinx youth related to policy making and community organizing activities.

5.1.2. Methodology domain

The CEED evaluators reported they increased their knowledge and skills in evaluation methodology including how to identify the evaluation needs for small organizations. For example, one CEED project leader described using a participatory evaluation approach to explore the needs of the community organization and learn how they could use evaluation to improve their programs. They summarized, "You learn a lot about how nonprofits work and how they use and value evaluation."

Early career evaluators who led CEED projects also described learning how to involve nonprofit stakeholders in the evaluation design. By working directly with staff in the recipient community nonprofit organizations, CEED lead evaluators reported they learned the importance of identifying affordable and sustainable methods of data collection. For example, one project leader developed instruments using tools the nonprofit organization was already using (Survey Monkey) while collaborating to streamline the existing data collection processes. Another project leader identified a user-friendly and cost-effective program (Google Sheets) to set up templates for data analysis that could be easily replicated. They describe how they learned from conversations with staff at the recipient nonprofit organization to determine what methods would work best for them and what would be most sustainable moving forward.

5.1.3. Planning and management domain

The area of planning and management was cited most frequently by CEED project leaders as an area of growth. They reported they

developed various project management skills such as creating a standard meeting agenda, managing the budget, and developing a scope of work. Serving as the project leader increased their confidence in their abilities to serve as the leader on other projects. For example, one CEED project leader described:

"I got so much out of it. I had never led a client meeting. I think it was a really good learning experience and confidence booster. Getting feedback from [my mentor] built my confidence to make me feel like I could lead other projects."

CEED project leaders reported they gained experience in documenting evaluation processes and products. For example, several leaders developed trainings and webinars for the staff at the recipient nonprofit organization. These trainings included sessions on qualitative data collection, qualitative coding, and data visualization. One CEED project leader developed a training on best-practices of survey development and dissemination; the training provided step-by-step instructions on how to download data and how to create data visualizations. During the pandemic, the trainings were held virtually and recorded to be available for viewing multiple times as needed for new staff to the recipient nonprofit organization or for use after the CEED evaluation concluded.

CEED project leaders noted they gained experience developing a variety of formats for reporting purposes. They described developing templates so that the recipient nonprofit organization staff could independently create charts and figures to demonstrate program outcomes in reports and presentations. They prepared training demonstrations including how to input data into pre-made Excel and PowerPoint templates to tailor visualizations to the target audience (e.g., general public, board of directors, or funders).

5.1.4. Interpersonal domain

AEA describes the domain of interpersonal skills to include cultural competence, communication, facilitation, and conflict resolution. CEED project leaders described how they built their facilitation skills by leading meetings and communicating with recipient nonprofit organizations' staff. One leader stated, *"Communicating with the client built my confidence. It was really helpful. After leading the CEED project, I'm more comfortable in talking with my other clients."*

Finally, several CEED project leaders described the importance of building relationships with staff at the recipient nonprofit organizations, an essential component of equitable evaluation. They reported they learned the importance of engaging in open and routine communication that helped to build trust over time.

5.2. Benefits for The Evaluation Center at CU Denver

Our team members who were involved with CEED noted organizational benefits of the initiative related to three themes. First, they shared an observation that offering *pro bono* services opened avenues to working with new organizations that otherwise might not have been encountered. Through our shift to focus on organizations that have an equity-focused mission, we observed that this initiative allowed us to conduct evaluations in content areas where we had not previously had experience such as environmental education, reproductive rights, adoption, and foster care. We were also able to apply and gain confidence in the implementation of equitable evaluation practices.

Second, our staff described an appreciation of the CEED program as an exemplar of The Evaluation Center's vision of "improved lives and communities through high-quality evaluation." By providing *pro bono* evaluation services, members of our team felt the CEED program aligned with the values of The Evaluation Center at CU Denver. A CEED mentor stated,

"I think it fits our organization's mission and vision of building better communities through evaluation. Through CEED, [we are] providing

services for smaller nonprofits that do good work. It aligns with what we hope to do as a center through evaluation."

A third and unanticipated benefit to The Evaluation Center at CU Denver that emerged during the focus group is that the CEED program provided mentorship opportunities for staff members at multiple stages of experience. Mid-career staff who served as mentors for the early career evaluator reported they gained competencies in providing feedback and guidance. They also reported that they in turn received mentorship and consultation from other mid-career and more experienced team members. The CEED projects provided an informal forum for staff at all levels of experience to share what they were learning, discuss challenges, and improve their skills within the context of the CEED project. One CEED mentor described serving as a mentor as a valuable learning experience:

"There was development of those skills as a mentor in how to teach someone. Giving them enough space and enough guidance to let them build confidence and also to feel supported as well. It was a good experience for me."

5.3. Benefits for recipient nonprofit organizations

Representatives of the recipient nonprofit organizations receiving CEED services reported their experiences helped them gain new perspectives on evaluation. Specifically, they described how CEED helped them to 1) gain a deeper understanding of evaluation design, 2) improve their dissemination efforts with partners and funders, and 3) build their organizational capacity to implement evaluations. However, some representatives noted challenges to fully implementing what they learned through their CEED experience.

5.3.1. Deeper understanding of evaluation design

CEED recipients reported an initial benefit was a deeper understanding of evaluation design. For example, interviewees stated how they learned about various evaluation methods, evaluation terminology, and how to focus an evaluation. Nearly all interviewees cited the logic model sessions as valuable. The interviewee from Org #3 noted they benefited from spending time to develop short, medium, and long-term goals and learning how to align these goals with evaluation questions. While interviewees from Org#2 reported they had previously participated in planning activities in the past, working with CEED evaluators helped them to narrow their focus and refine the metrics they were collecting. An individual from Org #1 stated, *"The day we did the logic model was really helpful to learn about our program through other folks' eyes to pull out some things we maybe wouldn't have seen otherwise."*

An executive leader at Org #4 reported a benefit of CEED participation was *"a better understanding of the various types of evaluation methods."* During their participation in CEED, the focus was on application of evaluation methods to one specific program. In a follow-up interview, the interviewee described how they have utilized and applied the same evaluation methods to other programs in their organization stating, *"It was really helpful for us going forward to have some evaluation tools in place that we can use for other programs."*

5.3.2. Improved dissemination

Recipient nonprofit organization representatives described how their CEED work resulted in a new eagerness to share data and evaluation findings, an unanticipated benefit. Interviewees described developing reports using aggregate data that they distributed in meetings and newsletters. At Org #2, they included new data visualizations in reports to their funders and in presentations to their board. An Org #1 interviewee reported developing case studies from newly collected data to share success stories with their network. An interviewee from Org #5 stated how they used their CEED evaluation report:

"The report we got is valuable internally to think through improving the program that was evaluated. There is a lot of great content in that report we can use for marketing with donors and funders and community communication. We can also draw content from the report to use in social media and to highlight our youth programming at large."

5.3.3. Built organizational evaluation capacity

Finally, interviewees reported their CEED experience helped them to build organizational capacity for evaluation. For Org #5 whose CEED project focused on qualitative data collection, the interviewees described how they will apply qualitative approaches to the evaluation of other programs in their organization. They added that they are also planning to *"train others on our team with what we learned from our partnership with CEED and keep that going beyond our role."* An interviewee from Org #4 stated that prior to CEED, *"We were trying to do some things through surveys, but we just didn't have an idea on the best approach. We were just trying to wing it."* Since their CEED experience, they reported they conduct routine data collection using standardized measures and survey best practices.

Similarly, an Org #2 interviewee described how they shared what they learned with others in their organization, stating the CEED program *"really makes a difference in a small organization with the small staff."* At Org #3 in the long-term follow-up interview, they reported that their new evaluation approaches helped them to secure additional funding and recruit new staff to their team to further their evaluation efforts. An Org #3 interviewee described how the CEED experience benefited their organization:

"It has helped us apply for grants. ... We now have three years of data to demonstrate that we do what we say our program is doing. We didn't have data and the CEED program provided us that piece that we didn't have. It has helped us expand our reach and get more money."

5.3.4. Challenges

Despite building capacity for evaluation, some representatives of recipient nonprofit organizations noted that there were challenges to continue the planned evaluation at the conclusion of CEED. Two challenges cited were "not enough time" and "not enough staff." The Org #4 interviewee explained how their internal data coordinator who participated in CEED was no longer with the organization. In another example, an Org #5 interviewee described having to pivot their evaluation design to align with their organization's new strategic plan while working with a small staff. They stated, *"We don't have ten different people trained and versed in this [evaluation] work. We have two. Turnover I think is also one of the challenges."* These reports are consistent with challenges reported by other small nonprofit organizations that are attempting to implement effective evaluation strategies (Carman & Milleson, 2005).

6. Discussion: lessons learned

In the implementation of the six *pro bono* evaluations, we have learned important lessons that we believe will improve the experience for future team members, our organization, and recipient nonprofit organizations. Part of our learning process was to identify the factors that make the *pro bono* experience a unique opportunity for CEED lead evaluators to gain competencies. While similar professional development could be provided by mentoring a new employee as they engage in fee-for-service evaluation work, we discovered the perceived effectiveness of the learning experience was enhanced by four factors:

1. Engaging content - The early career evaluator contributes to the identification of the criteria used to define the pool of applicants for *pro bono* services and to the selection of the recipient nonprofit

organization. Therefore, they understand and are engaged in the mission of the recipient organization from the onset, a factor not always present in fee-for-service evaluation projects where new team members may have little say in the selection of the client.

2. Leader role - The early career evaluator leads the evaluation with the support of a mentor, a role seldom assigned to more junior team members. They gain first-hand experience in engaging the client, decision making throughout the process, and being responsible for the delivery of high-quality evaluation and capacity building.
3. "Start to finish" experiences - The early career evaluator experiences the evaluation project from initial client engagement to completion of the mutually agreed upon deliverables. CEED projects have pre-determined budgets and short timelines. This experience differs from the work often assigned to more junior evaluators who may be joining an ongoing project or only see one dimension of the evaluation.
4. Self-reflection - CEED projects are designed to support the CEED lead evaluator in reflection about their learning during and after their experience. They also receive follow-up feedback from the staff in the recipient nonprofit organization, another process not always available to new evaluators. The increased awareness of their evaluator competency development and the benefits received by the clients is perceived as a rewarding and fulfilling experience for the new evaluator that contributes to their professional identification and commitment to the profession.

Another key lesson was the need to provide internal support and resources for the team member serving as the CEED mentor who may be new to the role of mentoring. For this purpose, we "mentored the mentor." We connected the CEED mentor with another team member with more mentoring experience to serve as a sounding board throughout the coaching process. As a result, the CEED mentor developed their coaching skills including ways to provide guidance without limiting the leadership role for the early career evaluator. We began to understand that the professional development of the CEED mentor was as important and valuable as the competency development of the more junior team member, an unintended and welcomed consequence of the program.

We also learned about the importance of providing the early career evaluator with specific guidance concerning the AEA Evaluator Competency "Negotiates and manages a feasible evaluation plan, budget, resources, and timeline." Because of the bounded time allotted for the *pro bono* work, this skill was essential to focus the evaluation while maximizing the benefit for the community organization. We found it helpful to provide the CEED lead evaluator with examples of short-term plans and to share ways to help the CEED client identify the essential elements of the evaluation they needed.

Finally, we reflected on the importance of providing ways for our partner recipient nonprofit organizations to sustain their evaluation work after the conclusion of the CEED project. We discovered it was important to prepare reference materials that would be available after our involvement was completed. This discovery was an accidental learning that occurred during the shift to virtual meetings prompted by the pandemic precautions. During this time, we began recording online training sessions and developing reference manuals for the recipient nonprofit organization groups. What we learned was that these materials were useful and promoted the sustainability of the evaluation work initiated during the CEED engagement. We plan to continue the sharing of training documents and videos in future CEED projects as a standard operating procedure.

6.1. Future research

Additional research is needed to examine the contextual factors necessary to implement *pro bono* evaluations that are intended to build evaluator competencies. What is the threshold for *pro bono* work to be

financially realistic in terms of the size of the sponsoring organization, their annual budget, and number of staff members? What is the necessary level of sustained commitment for both senior and junior team members and how is that determined? To what extent is it an important factor that The Evaluation Center is situated within CU Denver that has stated goals to positively impact the surrounding community (Goals for 2030, University of Colorado Denver, 2002) and therefore has organizational support to engage in community work?

While one purpose of this study was to explore the usefulness of the competencies as a structure for introductory evaluator experiences as suggested by Hall (2020), additional research is needed to examine other in-service professional development strategies that contribute to evaluator capacity. Likely, just as there are many entry points to the evaluator profession, there are many innovative ways to design and tailor continuing education experiences that will enhance evaluator competency and foster professional excellence.

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Susan C. Connors: Conceptualization, Methodology, Investigation, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing. **Goldie Komaie:** Formal analysis, Writing – original draft, Visualization. **Jeff Proctor:** Supervision, Writing – review & editing.

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Author Statement

Data presented in this article are available from the corresponding author.

Declarations of interest

none.

Appendix A. Supporting information

Supplementary data associated with this article can be found in the online version at [doi:10.1016/j.evalprogplan.2023.102346](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.evalprogplan.2023.102346).

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